

Power-sharing

Social Science — Civics • Chapter 1 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Why is sharing power important in a democracy? Imagine a country where one community, one party or one branch of government holds all the power. History shows this leads to violence and oppression. This chapter starts with two real stories — the ethnic conflict in Sri Lanka and the peaceful arrangement in Belgium — to explain why **power-sharing is the very spirit of democracy**.

The story of Belgium

Belgium is a small European country with a complex ethnic mix:

- 59% Dutch-speaking (in Flanders, the north), 40% French-speaking (in Wallonia, the south), 1% German-speaking.
- In the capital Brussels, French speakers were the majority (80%) but Dutch speakers were the majority in the country.
- French-speakers were richer and more powerful — this caused tensions in the 1950s-60s.

The Belgians worked out an innovative power-sharing arrangement between 1970 and 1993 (constitution amended four times!) so that **no one community can take decisions alone**. Key features:

- **Equal numbers** of Ministers from Dutch and French speakers in central government.
- **Many powers transferred** to state governments (federalism).
- **Brussels has its own** separate government with equal representation.
- A **community government** elected by people belonging to one language community — Dutch, French and German — has the power on cultural, educational and language-related issues.

The story of Sri Lanka

Sri Lanka has Sinhala speakers (74%) and Tamil speakers (18% — 'Sri Lankan Tamils' native to the island, 'Indian Tamils' brought by the British). Independence came in 1948. The Sinhala-majority government chose the opposite path:

- **1956 Act** — Sinhala became the only official language, ignoring Tamil.
- Government policies favoured Sinhala applicants for university and government jobs.
- Buddhism, the religion of Sinhala majority, was given state protection.
- Tamils felt politically discriminated and culturally suppressed.

Tamil grievances grew into a demand for **regional autonomy and equality of opportunity**. By the 1980s, this exploded into civil war — the LTTE (Tamil Tigers) vs Sri Lankan army — that killed thousands and destroyed the economy until 2009.

What we learn from these two cases

Belgium's careful sharing of power kept the country united and prosperous. Sri Lanka's **majoritarianism** (belief that the majority can decide on its own) led to civil war. Lesson: in a divided society, power must be shared between different communities. This is the wisdom behind power-sharing.

Why is power-sharing desirable?

Two reasons — one practical, one principled:

- **Prudential reason:** reduces conflict between social groups, ensures political stability — without it, society can become violent.
- **Moral reason:** the very spirit of democracy is people ruling themselves — so power must reach all those who are ruled.

Forms of power-sharing

Four major forms of power-sharing in modern democracies:

1. HORIZONTAL : Among different organs of government
(Legislature - Executive - Judiciary)
'Checks and balances'
2. VERTICAL : Among different LEVELS of government
(Central - State - Local). Federalism.
3. SOCIAL : Among different SOCIAL GROUPS
(linguistic / religious / ethnic).
e.g. Belgium's community government,
reservations in legislatures.
4. POLITICAL : Among PARTIES, PRESSURE GROUPS, MOVEMENTS
(coalition governments, opposition, civil society)

Why all four forms matter

Each form addresses a different threat. Horizontal sharing prevents tyranny (Montesquieu's idea of separation of powers). Vertical sharing meets the demand of regions for autonomy. Social sharing recognises diversity, gives every group a voice. Political sharing keeps any one party from dominating forever — elections, opposition, free press, social movements ensure it. Together they make democracy real and not just elections-based 'rule of the majority'.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Power-sharing is the very spirit of democracy.
- Belgium = successful power-sharing; Sri Lanka = majoritarianism led to civil war.
- Belgium has 4 levels: central, state, community government, and local — equal Dutch-French representation in centre.
- Sri Lanka 1956 Act made Sinhala the only official language.
- Two reasons for power-sharing: prudential (reduces conflict) and moral (essence of democracy).
- Four forms: horizontal (organs), vertical (levels — federalism), social (groups), political (parties/movements).
- Montesquieu — separation of powers (checks and balances).

— End of Summary —